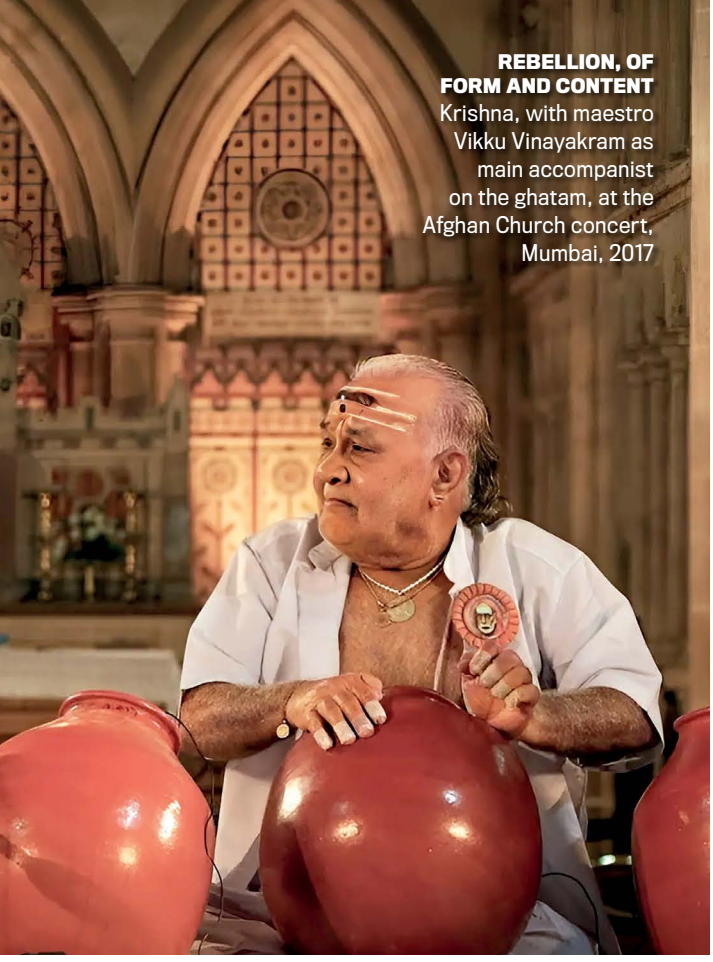


REBELLION, OF FORM AND CONTENT
Krishna, with maestro Vikku Vinayakram as main accompanist on the ghatam, at the Afghan Church concert, Mumbai, 2017



"Krishna is responding to an artistic restlessness, experimenting with form as part of his political curiosity. He set a new discourse by rehabilitating the ghatam as the main accompaniment"

–LAKSHMI SUBRAMANIAN
Author, music historian

yond its codes. In his practice, he began performing those gestures of internal critique. Over a century, Carnatic had devolved into a kind of closed circuit, conjuring its self-image around a serene, satvik aura. For that Brahmin lifeworld, whose aromatic air generations had breathed deeply of, what Krishna did was disruptive, subversive. It was meant to be. He crossed the silken boundaries of that world, taking his music to mosques and churches, singing even in "a lungi and skull cap". He conceptualised the Urur-Olcott Kuppam Vizha, a festival at a fishing village in Chennai's Besant Nagar. Kuppam, 'hamlet' in Tamil, is a word so loaded with stigma that a Dalit politician had asked for it to be excised from official use—so, sociologically, this was planets away from the sandal-scented sabhas where Carnatic was ordinarily resident. He sang the poetry of Perumal Murugan. And the highest sacrilege, he invoked Periyar.

In short, he became, in the words of poet Meena Kandasamy, a "caste traitor". A category of violator for whom, she told INDIA TODAY, "Brahmin tradition has always reserved the highest punishment." As the floodwaters of rage broke all embankments, Kandasamy's own timeline on X saw a thousand-fold spike in footfalls—a splenetic avalanche of trolling after she asked for proof that Periyar had ever called for a "Brahmin genocide". For her, Krishna's invocation of Periyar was not too much but too little. "A single act of transgression", from a position of privilege, that only made the darkness visible, magnifying the old narrative of "Brahmin victimhood" that she finds specious and reductive.

At its core is positing Periyar as the sole cause of the 'Brahmin exodus' from Tamil lands. In reality, many left for new jobs in the colonial cities, Kandasamy says. "People create a collective false memory: in the Cauvery Delta, Brahmins were big landlords. The threat to that hegemony came not just from Periyarite ideology but also a simultaneous challenge from organised Communism, some of whose leaders were Brahmin," she says. The arc of Periyar's positive influence, she feels, is under-acknowledged. "The Brahmin women criticising Krishna don't realise the gender freedom they take for granted owes directly to Periyar's rational modernity."

Clearly, this is a story where caste and music—*swara* and *jaati*, if you like—are warp and woof. Caste has its primary articulation, raw and visceral, in the world out there. Carnatic was performing caste *within* music, and Krishna was consciously disrupting those rites of exclusion by attempting to (re)connect the "classical" to non-Brahmin experiential and aesthetic fields. "He was repositioning Carnatic—on the logic that you can't have music that is not political. I cannot but empathise with that," says music historian Lakshmi Subramanian, an authority on Carnatic's social ecology. For her, he was confronting two issues that "tradition always skirted"—the power-caste complex, and the suffusion of the repertoire with "sanitised bhakti of a certain kind", with no room for a vast and vital field out there, the ecstatic-orgiastic Tamil spiritual soil, teeming with Mariammans and her